GENERAL OFFICE STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURES

Workplace rules, employee conduct and daily office procedures

Purpose

This document sets out the basic rules and procedures that help the office operate safely, consistently and professionally. It applies to employees and, where relevant, interns, contractors and visitors. Managers are responsible for explaining these rules and applying them fairly.

Policy owner: *Operations / Human Resources* ***Version:*** *1.0* ***Status:*** *Draft for approval*

1. Office Hours and Attendance

Standard hours should be confirmed in each employee's contract or staff handbook. The following schedule is an example and should be adjusted to suit the business:

Item	Procedure
Office hours	Example: Monday to Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m.
Attendance	Employees must start work on time and use the approved attendance method, if one is in place.
Late arrival	Inform the line manager as early as possible, explain the expected arrival time, and record the delay as required.
Unexpected absence	Notify the manager before the workday begins where possible. In an emergency, contact them as soon as reasonably practical.
Remote or flexible work	Requires prior manager approval. Employees must remain contactable and complete agreed work.

Managers should keep attendance records accurate and address repeated lateness or unexplained absence consistently. Employees should promptly report any error in their records.

2. Leave Procedures

- Submit planned leave to the line manager through the company's approved form, email or HR system as early as possible.
- Wait for approval before treating planned leave as confirmed. Managers should consider workload and team coverage before responding.
- For sickness or emergencies, notify the manager as soon as possible. Any supporting documentation must be handled confidentially and requested in accordance with company policy and applicable law.
- Before planned leave, provide a short handover covering current tasks, deadlines, key files and urgent matters.
- Request an extension before the approved return date where possible. HR or the designated administrator should update the leave record after approval.
- Leave entitlements must follow the employment contract, company policy and applicable law.

3. Dress Code and Workplace Conduct

- Wear clean, neat and workplace-appropriate clothing suitable for the role, client meetings and any safety requirements. Business-casual clothing is the default unless otherwise advised.

- Treat colleagues, customers, suppliers and visitors with respect. Use courteous language and communicate professionally in person, by email and in work chat.
- Harassment, bullying, discrimination, threats, violence and retaliation are prohibited. Raise concerns with HR or a designated senior manager.
- Protect confidential business, employee and customer information. Share it only with authorized people and use approved work systems.
- Use work time responsibly. Personal activities must not interfere with duties, customer service, safety or agreed deadlines.
- Declare any conflict of interest and do not use company information, assets or relationships for unauthorized personal benefit.
- Dress and conduct requirements must be applied fairly and reasonably, with appropriate accommodation where required by law.

4. Cleanliness, Health and Safety

- Keep desks, meeting rooms, kitchen areas and shared facilities clean and ready for others to use.
- Dispose of waste properly and follow any recycling or food-storage arrangements.
- Report spills, damaged furniture, exposed wiring, faulty equipment or other hazards to the responsible manager. Do not attempt repairs unless authorized.
- Keep exits, walkways, fire equipment and accessible routes clear at all times.
- Follow building security, evacuation, first-aid and emergency instructions. Report workplace injuries and near misses promptly.
- At the end of the workday, secure confidential papers, lock devices, and leave shared areas tidy.

5. Meetings and Communication

- The organizer should set a clear purpose, invite the necessary people and share an agenda in advance when practical.
- Arrive on time, prepare for the discussion, silence non-essential notifications and allow others to contribute without interruption.
- Record important decisions, action items, responsible people and due dates. Share notes with relevant participants after the meeting.
- Do not record meetings or distribute recordings, screenshots or confidential notes without proper authorization and consent.
- Use clear subject lines and respectful language in emails. Check recipients before sending sensitive information.
- Use approved company accounts and tools for work. Never share passwords or authentication codes.
- Use the agreed urgent-contact method for emergencies rather than relying only on email.

6. Office Equipment, Resources and Shared Spaces

- Use company computers, phones, printers, software, stationery and internet access primarily for authorized business purposes.
- Do not install unapproved software, disable security settings, lend equipment to unauthorized users or attempt unauthorized repairs.
- Report lost, stolen, damaged or malfunctioning equipment promptly to the line manager, Operations or IT support.
- Obtain approval before purchasing supplies or removing company equipment from the office.

- Book meeting rooms using the agreed process. Finish on time, remove personal items, clean the whiteboard and return furniture to its place.
- Respect colleagues' belongings and keep kitchens and break areas clean.
- Save business files in approved company locations and follow access permissions. Do not keep the only copy of important work on a personal device.

7. Employee Responsibilities and Reporting Lines

Employees normally report to their assigned line manager or team lead. Issues may then be referred to Operations, HR or senior management depending on their nature. The company should communicate its actual reporting structure to all staff.

Issue	First point of contact	Escalate if
Tasks, workload or deadlines	Line manager / team lead	Priorities remain unclear or a client commitment is at risk.
Attendance or leave	Line manager, then HR / administrator	A record is disputed or the request is not resolved.
Equipment or IT issue	IT support / Operations	Security, privacy, safety or business continuity may be affected.
Harassment or serious misconduct	HR or a trusted senior manager	The normal contact is involved or no appropriate action is taken.
Safety emergency or suspected data breach	Designated senior leader / security contact; emergency services if needed	Immediately, following the relevant emergency procedure.

- Understand your role, responsibilities and performance expectations.
- Follow approved procedures and ask for clarification if an instruction is unclear or appears unsafe.
- Meet agreed deadlines and notify the manager early about delays or risks.
- Complete required training, protect company information and use resources responsibly.
- Raise concerns honestly and in good faith. Retaliation against a person who reports a concern in good faith is not permitted.

8. Incident Reporting and Escalation

1. **Make the situation safe.** If there is immediate danger, protect people first and contact emergency services or building security as appropriate.
2. **Notify the appropriate contact promptly.** This may be the line manager, Operations, HR, IT/security or a senior leader.
3. **Record the facts.** Include the date, time, location, people involved, impact and actions already taken. Avoid speculation.
4. **Preserve relevant records.** Do not delete potentially relevant messages, files or logs, and do not conduct an unauthorized investigation.
5. **Review and resolve.** The designated owner assesses the risk, takes appropriate action and records follow-up responsibilities.

Reports should be handled discreetly and shared only with people who need the information to respond. Employees should not be penalized for making a good-faith report.

9. Disciplinary Procedure

Disciplinary action should be fair, proportionate, consistent and based on the facts. The employee should have a reasonable opportunity to explain their position before a formal decision is made.

Stage	Action
1. Informal discussion	For minor or first-time issues, explain the concern, clarify expectations and agree on improvement steps where appropriate.
2. Fact-finding	For repeated or serious issues, gather relevant information and give the employee an opportunity to respond.
3. Written warning or improvement plan	If justified, document the concern, required change, support available and review period.
4. Further action	Review the evidence, severity, prior steps and employee response before deciding on any further action permitted by law and contract.
5. Appeal	Allow an appeal to a manager or senior leader who was not directly responsible for the original decision, where practicable.

Potential breaches include repeated lateness, unauthorized absence, failure to follow reasonable workplace or safety rules, misuse of company property, harassment, fraud, theft, retaliation or serious confidentiality breaches. The response depends on the circumstances; no penalty should be automatic. Significant measures, including termination or deductions, must comply with applicable law and employment terms.

Keep records of formal concerns, the employee’s response, decisions and appeals in a secure, restricted-access location. Where a complaint involves the employee’s manager or HR contact, provide an alternative reporting route.

10. Policy Review and Approval

Step	Requirement	Responsible person
1	Draft or update the policy and explain the reason for the change.	Operations / HR
2	Review practicality, employee impact, safety, privacy and legal requirements.	Relevant managers; legal adviser if needed
3	Approve the final version and effective date.	CEO / Founder or authorized approver
4	Share the approved policy with staff and explain significant changes.	HR / Operations
5	Record acknowledgement where required and withdraw outdated copies.	HR / document owner

- Review this policy at least annually and sooner if laws, safety requirements, business operations or working arrangements change significantly.
- Employees may suggest improvements to their manager or HR. Urgent concerns should be reviewed without waiting for the annual review.
- Each approved revision should show its version, approval date, effective date, document owner and summary of changes.
- If this policy conflicts with applicable law or an employment contract, the law or contract takes precedence.

Employee Acknowledgement

I acknowledge that I have received or been given access to this policy. I understand that I am responsible for reading it, asking questions if anything is unclear, and following the approved procedures. This acknowledgement does not replace applicable law or my employment contract.

Employee name		Department / role	
Employee signature		Date	
Manager / HR representative		Date received	

Before issuing this policy, confirm the company's actual office hours, leave entitlements, attendance system, reporting contacts and local legal requirements. This document is a general template and should be reviewed by management before use.